

RIVER-CITIES ALLIANCE

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Based on the vision of the Hon'ble Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi to entrench river-centric mindset in planning for cities on river banks, the first-of-its-kind initiative – River Cities Alliance (RCA) was launched by the Union Minister for Jal Shakti Shri Gajendra Singh Shekhawat in November 2021. The primary objective of the RCA, funded by National Mission for Clean Ganga (NMCG) and implemented jointly with the National Institute of Urban Affairs (NIUA), is to incorporate River Management as one of the key elements of Urban planning and to provide its member cities (city on the banks of a river) a platform to ideate, network and co-learn to foster river centric development. Preparation of Urban River Management Plans (URMP) with ideas for: sustainable river management with emphasis on reduction of liquid/solid pollution in the river flowing by the city; promotion of "Catch The Rain" concepts to maximize rain water harvesting and conserving urban lakes and water bodies to maintain ecological flow in the urban rivers; abatement of urban floods (making room for rivers!) and other climate change related impacts; breaking silos in water management; taking steps to ensure water security following the 5-R (Recycle, Reuse, Reduce, Recharge and Respect) principles; promotion of better water governance with appropriate water pricing; reducing/banning the use of potable water for all not potable uses; reducing Non-Revenue Water; democratizing access to 24*7 Water supply etc can be facilitated and best practices shared. RCA is to bestow water and rivers its place in urban planning as engines for tourism (river cruises!) and economic growth, and incidentally also improves aesthetics of the city; health of people, real-estate value of their river front property and inturn the tax revenue to ULBs!

It all started with a consortium of IITs suggestion to connect urban-governance and river-management in India. On 16,17th May, 2019 a kickoff workshop was held at IIT, Kanpur, with officials of Kanpur Nagar Nigam, experts from NIUA/NMCG and other stakeholders participating. Despite Covid restrictions, Kanpur's URMP – the first of its kind- was finally compiled and released in 2021. In the meanwhile, NMCG, in collaboration with NIUA, came up with guidelines to bring river management into the mainstream governance at the municipality level. In November 2020,

> There is a need for new thinking for 'River Cities'. There is need for the residents of these cities to ask, 'What can we do for the rivers?' There is a need for a new river centric thinking in planning for cities on the banks of rivers. The river health needs to be mainstreamed into urban planning process by developing Urban River Management Plans. Cities should be responsible for rejuvenating their rivers. It has to be done not just with the regulatory mindset but also with developmental and facilitatory outlook.
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> **Hon'ble Prime Minister**
> during the first meeting of National Ganga Council held on December 14, 2019